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ENG 101: Nigerian Literature in English - Texts, Contexts and Close Reading

A reading method for the novels, plays and poems on your first-year list

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
English Language & Literature | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

First-year literature is not about memorising plots; it is about making defensible claims from evidence. This pack covers the historical shaping of Nigerian literature in English, the shift from cultural nationalism to critique of the nation, and a close-reading method you can apply to any text on the list.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Place a text in the phases of Nigerian literary history.
- Distinguish close reading from plot summary.
- Analyse narrative voice, imagery and structure.
- Build an argument supported by quotation.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

A short map of the field

Know the phases well enough to date and situate a text.

- Cultural nationalism and the generation that wrote back to colonial representation.
- Independence-era optimism and its rapid disillusionment.
- Civil war literature and the literature of trauma.
- Postcolonial critique of the nation-state, elite politics and corruption.
- Diaspora writing and the global circulation of Nigerian fiction.
- Contemporary writing on gender, sexuality, migration and technology.

Close reading, step by step

The method is repeatable and it earns marks.

1. Choose a short passage that clearly matters to the text.
2. Note its literal content in one sentence.
3. Analyse diction: which words are unexpected and why?
4. Analyse imagery and figurative language.
5. Analyse syntax and rhythm: short clauses or long accumulations?
6. Connect the passage to a pattern in the whole text and to your argument.

> **Quote precisely**
> A short quotation, correctly embedded and analysed, beats a long block quotation that is never discussed.

Context without overreach

Biography explains less than you think.

- Use history to explain textual choices, not to replace analysis.
- Avoid reading a character as the author's autobiography.
- Note publication date and reception when they matter.
- Treat oral tradition as form and influence, not as background colour.
- Read the introduction and notes, then form your own reading.
- Cite editions consistently.

A literature with a history of argument

Nigerian literature in English begins in contest. The first generation wrote against colonial representation and against the assumption that African life was raw material for European interpretation. Chinua Achebe's Things Fall Apart (1958) answered novels that treated Igbo society as backdrop by placing its institutions, proverbs and internal debates at the centre.

The language question followed immediately. Achebe argued for a "new English" that could carry African experience; Ngugi wa Thiong'o argued that writing in colonial languages perpetuates colonial power and moved to Gikuyu. The debate is not settled, and a good answer treats it as a live argument with consequences for who reads, who teaches and who is translated.

Periods are useful but must be handled carefully. Pre-independence writing is often read through cultural nationalism; the post-war generation through disillusionment and experimental form; the contemporary period through diaspora, gender, migration and genre fiction. These labels describe tendencies, not rules.

Reading the text and the tradition together